Policy 06 — Age Verification

Operator	[COMPANY NAME], trading as PlayStake
Owner	[COMPLIANCE LEAD NAME], Head of Compliance
Version	0.1 — draft for licence application
Review	Annually, and when an electronic verification provider is appointed
Relates to	Licensing objective 3 (protecting children); Gambling Act 2005 ss.46–47 (inviting or permitting a child or young person to gamble); LCCP social responsibility code 3.2.11 (remote age verification: verify age before a customer can deposit, access free-to-play games, or gamble); LCCP customer identity verification requirements

> Draft for review by a compliance adviser. LCCP references to be confirmed against the current version.

1. Purpose

The law prohibits anyone under 18 from gambling. PlayStake goes further: **customers must be 21 or over and live in England, Scotland or Wales** (the confirmed launch scope, Policy 00 v0.2, decided 28 October 2026). Remote operators must verify a customer's age **before** they can deposit, access free-to-play games, or gamble. This policy explains how PlayStake verifies age and residency, and what happens if an under-18 gets through (an under-18 is closed as under-18; an 18–20-year-old or a non-GB resident is refused).

2. Principles

- **Verify first.** Age is verified before any deposit, any free-to-play game, and any gambling. No product lets anyone play first and verify later.
- **Fail closed.** Anything short of full verification blocks all gambling.
- **No shortcuts.** Staff cannot mark a customer as age-verified without an approved identity document showing they are 21 or over and an address in England, Scotland or Wales. The platform enforces this.

3. How age is verified

3.1 At sign-up

- **Email sign-up.** Customers who sign up with email must give their date of birth and actively tick a box confirming they are 21 or over and live in England, Scotland or Wales. The box also confirms that their age and identity will be checked before they can deposit or play. Anyone whose date of birth makes them under 21 is refused, and no account is created. The date of birth and the time of the confirmation are recorded.

- **Google sign-in.** Customers who sign in with Google do not give a date of birth at sign-up. They go through exactly the same identity verification (section 3.2) before they can deposit or play.
- **Marketing.** Marketing consent is a separate, unticked, optional box.

Sign-up does not verify age. It only stops someone under 21 who admits their age from opening an account. Verification happens in section 3.2.

3.2 Identity and age verification (KYC)

Before any deposit, free-to-play access or gambling, the customer must complete identity verification. The steps are:

1. **Email address verified first.**
2. **Electronic verification with Didit (the normal route).** The customer completes Didit's hosted check, which:
    - reads and checks the identity document for authenticity and tampering (passport, driving licence, national ID card or residence permit, from any country; expired documents are declined)
    - runs a passive liveness check and matches the selfie to the document photo
    - declines anyone the document shows is under 18 (Didit's age rule; [SET to 21 in the Didit workflow]); PlayStake itself refuses anyone under 21
    - checks a proof of address issued in the last 3 months (utility bill, bank statement or government letter)
    - screens the customer against sanctions, PEP and adverse-media lists, and re-screens them as the lists change

    PlayStake re-reads Didit's decision from Didit's API with its own key (never trusting a webhook body alone) and records it as a submission. Didit approves automatically only when every step passes; anything borderline (a possible AML match, a borderline face match, an unclear proof of address) comes back "In Review" for staff.
3. **Upload for manual review (fallback).** If Didit is unavailable, or the customer can't use it, they enter their legal name, date of birth and address, and upload a passport (photo page), a driving licence or national ID card (front and back), and a selfie.

    Automatic checks on an upload:

    - the date of birth entered must show the customer is 21 or over
    - the address must be in Great Britain: country GB and not a Northern Ireland (BT) postcode
    - files must be genuine images or PDFs (checked from the file contents, not the file name) and no larger than 8 MB
    - documents are encrypted as soon as they are received (AES-256-GCM)
4. **Identity screening:**
    - the document date of birth is compared with the one given at sign-up; a mismatch opens a case and blocks approval

- the same name and date of birth, or the same document image, on another account opens a case and blocks approval (one person, one account)
- GAMSTOP is checked (Policy 04)

5. **Decision.**
   - **Didit approved:** the customer is verified automatically only if the document date of birth shows they are 21 or over, **the proof of address is in Great Britain** (country GB, not a BT postcode), **and** no identity case is open. An 18–20-year-old, or a proof of address outside Great Britain, is rejected automatically with the reason. Residency is taken from the proof of address, never from where a passport was issued; with no proof of address the submission waits for staff. Otherwise the submission waits for staff.
   - **Didit declined:** rejected with Didit's reasons; the customer can try again.
   - **Didit in review, or any upload:** staff review it at `/admin/kyc`, seeing Didit's results (document, liveness, face match, proof of address, AML) and opening the session in Didit's console for the images. For an upload, the reviewer checks that:
   - the document is genuine and unaltered, and not expired
   - the name and date of birth on the document match what the customer entered
   - the selfie matches the document photo
   - the address is plausible and consistent
6. **Age and residency re-checked at approval.** When the reviewer approves, the platform re-checks age from the document's date of birth and the address. It refuses approval if the customer is under 18 (and tells the reviewer to close the account as under-18), under 21, or lives outside Great Britain. 6a. **Re-checked before every deposit and stake.** The eligibility gate checks the approved identity again, so customers verified before the 21+ and Great Britain rules who don't meet them can't deposit or stake; they can still withdraw.
7. **Decision.** Every approval and rejection is recorded, with the reviewer and their notes, in the admin audit log. A rejection must include a reason, which the customer is told.

Electronic verification provider. Didit (didit.me) was appointed in October 2026 (Master Manual §8 item 4). Before real-money launch: sign Didit's data processing agreement, confirm where data is processed and stored, complete the DPIA (Document 17), and consider adding Didit's UK electoral-roll or credit-reference check so the address can be verified without a document.

3.2a Changes of address

Verified customers must tell us if they move (Terms §04). On **Verify ID → Update my address** they prove the new address with a Didit check (a proof-of-address workflow, `DIDIT_ADDRESS_WORKFLOW_ID`, if configured; otherwise the full check). The customer **stays verified** throughout.

- **Approved by Didit:** the new address replaces the old one (a new approved record; earlier addresses stay on file). An address outside England, Scotland and Wales is still recorded truthfully; the eligibility gate then stops deposits and stakes, and withdrawals remain open.
- **Declined:** the previous address stays; the customer sees Didit's reasons and can try again.

- **In review, no usable address, or a name or date of birth that doesn't match the verified identity:** staff decide in the KYC queue (shown as "Address update"). Approving or rejecting an address update never changes the customer's verified status.

3.3 Where verification is enforced

The eligibility check (Master Manual §5.1) requires verified identity for every one of these actions:

Action	Blocked until verified?
Depositing	Yes
Issuing or accepting a challenge (the only way to enter a match since the on-site games and lobby were withdrawn on 25 October 2026)	Yes
Having a stake locked when an opponent accepts a match	Yes (the opponent is re-checked)
Withdrawing	Yes
Applying to be a referee	Verified identity is required before approval and before officiating

Explaining the block. A notice on the games page tells an unverified customer they can't play yet and links to verification.

No manual override. Staff cannot set a customer to "verified" by hand unless an approved identity document shows they are 18 or over. The attempt is refused.

4. If an under-18 is found

An under-18 may be found in several ways: at verification, through a document review, a report from a parent, or information from a payment provider. Whenever it happens, staff act at once:

1. **Close the account as under-18** from the customer's admin page, giving a reason. The platform then automatically:
   - **voids every unsettled bet** they are party to, returning both players' stakes, because an under-18 cannot lawfully win or lose a bet
   - withdraws their lobby entries, invites and challenges
   - signs them out everywhere and prevents them signing in again
   - records the action, including their balance at the time and the voided bets, in the admin audit log
2. **Return their money.** The Head of Compliance arranges for the account's deposits to be returned to their source, outside the platform. Winnings are not paid.
3. **Review settled bets.** For bets that settled before the account was closed, the Head of Compliance reviews each one:
   - stakes the customer lost are returned as part of step 2
   - opponents who lost money to the under-18 are refunded by PlayStake where appropriate
   - every decision is recorded on the customer's record
4. **Consider reporting.** Decide whether to report to the Gambling Commission (for example, as a key event if a control failed) and whether safeguarding concerns need to be raised.

5. **Learn.** Establish how the customer got through verification, and fix the cause.

An under-18 closure **cannot be reversed**. Someone who has since turned 18 must open a new account and be fully verified.

5. Marketing and product design

- PlayStake's marketing is aimed only at adults. It does not use content, games, influencers or channels with particular appeal to under-18s.
- The site footer and every email footer state "21+ only", and the Terms of Service set 21 as the minimum age and require residence in England, Scotland or Wales. Email footers also carry GamCare's free support number.
- Streamer partners on Kick must be 21 or over and verified. Their PlayStake content must not target under-18s.

6. Monitoring and testing

The Head of Compliance carries out checks every quarter:

- **Sample check.** Re-check a sample of approved identity verifications against their documents.
- **Test the controls.** Confirm that an unverified test account cannot deposit, enter the games or stake. The automated test suite also checks this on every code change.

The results are included in the quarterly board compliance report.

7. Records

- **Identity documents:** kept encrypted for the retention period in the Privacy Policy. They are only ever decrypted when a reviewer deliberately opens them.
- **Verification decisions:** kept even if the account is deleted, and recorded in the audit log.
- **Under-18 closures:** permanent on the account.

8. Review

Version	Date	Change
0.1	30 September 2026	First draft